Wednesday, November 11, 2026
Memorial

St. Martin of Tours

Bishop and Confessor · Feast, November 11



Saint Martin and the Beggar, El Greco, c. 1597–99, National Gallery of Art, Washington[1]

1. El Greco, *Saint Martin and the Beggar*, oil on canvas, c. 1597–99, National Gallery of Art, Washington; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** born at Sabaria in Pannonia (today Szombathely, Hungary). His father was a military tribune, and the family moved to Pavia in Italy.[2]
- **Born:** about 316.[3]
- **Died:** at Candes in Touraine, most probably in 397, at about eighty-one.[4]
- **Feast:** November 11. It is still kept solemnly each year in his church at Tours.[5]
- **Titles:** Bishop of Tours, consecrated on July 4, about 371–372; monk and soldier.[6]

✠ His Life in Brief

Martin's parents were pagans, and his father was a soldier.[7] When the law required the sons of veterans to be enrolled, Martin was taken into the army at fifteen, though he had already asked to be a catechumen at ten.[8]

- At the gate of Amiens on a bitter winter day he met a beggar with no clothes. Martin had nothing but his weapons and his cloak, so he cut the cloak in two with his sword and gave half to

2. "St. Martin of Tours," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 9 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1910).
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid.
5. Ibid.
6. Ibid.
7. Sulpicius Severus, *On the Life of St. Martin*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 11, trans. Alexander Roberts (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1894), ch. 2.
8. Ibid.

the man.[9] That night he saw Christ wearing the half he had given, who said to the angels, "Martin, who is still but a catechumen, clothed me with this robe."[10]

- Soon after, at about twenty, he was baptized.[11] Before a battle in Gaul he asked the Caesar Julian for his discharge: "I am the soldier of Christ: it is not lawful for me to fight."[12]
- He then went to Poitiers to become a disciple of St. Hilary.[13] Around 361 he settled at Ligugé, where many monks gathered around him, and the monastery there grew into a famous abbey.[14]
- In 371 or 372 the people of Tours seized him for their bishop by popular acclamation, because he had refused every request.[15] He kept the life of a monk, and a new monastery, Marmoutier, grew up around his cell across the Loire.[16] He preached the Gospel through the countryside, where idolatry still held the villages.[17]
- When Priscillian, a Spanish heretic, was accused before the Emperor Maximus, Martin went to Trier to keep him from the secular court, "not indeed to defend" his doctrines. Maximus gave in to Bishop Ithacius and had Priscillian beheaded.[18]

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9. Sulpicius Severus, *On the Life of St. Martin*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 11, trans. Alexander Roberts (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1894), ch. 3.
10. Ibid.
11. Ibid.
12. Sulpicius Severus, *On the Life of St. Martin*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 11, trans. Alexander Roberts (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1894), ch. 4.
13. "St. Martin of Tours," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid.
18. Ibid.

Grieved, Martin refused for a time to communicate with Ithacius.[19]

- He died at Candes, where he had gone to make peace among the clergy; Sulpicius says almost two thousand monks came to his funeral.[20] [21]

✠ Famous Excerpt: *On the Life of St. Martin*, ch. 4

> *"Hitherto I have served you as a soldier: allow me now to become a soldier to God: let the man who is to serve you receive your donative: I am the soldier of Christ: it is not lawful for me to fight."*[22]

> These words are Martin's answer to Julian Caesar, as his biographer Sulpicius Severus tells it.[23]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: Christ is met in the poor. Martin gave half his cloak to a beggar, and Christ then showed him wearing it, "clothed me with this robe."[24] Sulpicius notes that the Lord was recalling his own words: "Inasmuch as you have done these things to one of the least of these, you have done them unto me" (Matthew 25:40).[25]

Exercise: have students read Matthew 25:31–46 and name one practical way to "clothe" Christ this week.

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19. Ibid.

20. Sulpicius Severus, *Letter* 3, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 11, trans. Alexander Roberts (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1894).

21. Ibid.

22. Sulpicius, *Life of Martin*, ch. 4.

23. Ibid.

24. Sulpicius, *Life of Martin*, ch. 3.

25. Ibid.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection 1: "Faith in Christ is a cover for cowardice." Martin met this charge directly. When Julian said he was only afraid of the battle, he offered to stand unarmed in front of the line the next day, "protected by the sign of the cross."[26] The enemy asked for peace before the battle began.[27]

Objection 2: "The Church wants the state's sword used against heretics." Martin disagreed with the bishops who pressed for Priscillian's execution. He went to Trier not to defend the heresy but to remove him from the emperor's jurisdiction, and he refused to communicate with Ithacius, the accuser.[28] [29] He later made peace with Ithacius to save the lives of two rebels, and reproached himself for this act of weakness.[30]

✠ 3. Theology

- **Christ in the least of his brothers:** the cloak and the vision show the teaching of Matthew 25 in a single act.[31]
- **Monk and bishop:** as bishop he stayed "the same as he had been before," with the same humility in his heart and the same plainness in his clothes.[32]
- **Surrender to God's will:** on his deathbed he said, "if I am still necessary to your people, I do not shrink from toil: your will be

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26. Sulpicius, *Life of Martin*, ch. 4.
27. Ibid.
28. "St. Martin of Tours," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
29. Ibid.
30. Ibid.
31. Sulpicius, *Life of Martin*, ch. 3.
32. Sulpicius Severus, *On the Life of St. Martin*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 11, trans. Alexander Roberts (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1894), ch. 10.

done."[33]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect, Memorial of St. Martin of Tours (Roman Missal, November 11):[34]
O God, who were magnified in the life of Saint Martin as in his death, renew the wonders of your grace in our hearts, so that neither death nor life may separate us from your love.

Martin's own prayer, as Sulpicius records it at his deathbed:[35]
O Lord, if I am still necessary to your people, I do not shrink from toil: your will be done.

Practice: Give something of your own, a coat or a meal, to someone who needs it today, and say Martin's short prayer as you do.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Martin gave half of what he had to a stranger and found it was given to Christ.[36]

St. Martin of Tours, pray for us.

33. Sulpicius, *Letter* 3.
34. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., Memorial of St. Martin of Tours (November 11), Collect.
35. Sulpicius, *Letter* 3.
36. Sulpicius, *Life of Martin*, ch. 3.